imperialism did not disappear with the end of the diversified industrial model; it only assumed new forms under the new specialised productive export pattern.[10] Why did privatisation and the de-nationalisation of export enterprises and of the banking system not make Brazil and the other countries in the region equal? Why were the local bourgeoisie and the Brazilian state not simply absorbed by foreign capital, as in other countries, but instead acted in an integrated manner as assistants – and even as protagonists – of the process of de-nationalisation on the continent? The condition of the sub-imperialist country is the key to explaining these peculiarities.

Antagonistic cooperation with imperialism through conjunctures

The category used to express state action in different conjunctures in a sub-imperialist socio-economic formation is antagonistic cooperation. It has been defined as a search for relative autonomy within the dependency framework: 'The relations between the Brazilian bourgeoisie and imperialism have to be viewed within the laws of antagonistic co-operation which is established in the course of international capitalist integration.' Antagonistic cooperation means that a sub-imperialist country never leaves the state of a dependent economy. It is not an imperialist country: 'Without being able to question imperialist dominion itself (otherwise it would mean questioning capitalism itself) the national bourgeoisie can only bargain for better relations within its subordinate status – better prices, better agreements, the appropriate areas for exploitation, etc.' (Martins, nd).

As proposed, in sub-imperialism antagonistic cooperation with centre imperialism expresses a search for relative autonomy in international politics and for control over a part of surplus value, so that the economy not only transmits but also appropriates surplus value. Not every dependent country that enters the monopoly and finance capital stage unites the conditions to practise an antagonistic cooperation policy. Besides, 'such relations [in terms of antagonistic cooperation] depend upon power relations in each situation: the economic conjuncture nationally and internationally, the political situation, the periods of détente and escalation with revolutionary forces, etc.' (Martins, nd).

Where this was not possible, the new nature of dependency reinforced subordination. Where, on the contrary, relations with dominant centres were of the antagonistic cooperation type, it was because the conditions for relative autonomy had been created, developing the sub-imperialist formation. This is the sense of Marini's weighty deliberation: 'As in Brazil, countries such as Argentina, Israel, Iran, Iraq and South Africa take on – or took on, in some moment of their recent evolution – the sub-imperialistic character along with other sub-